PRIVATE AVIATION, DECODED

The Charter Buyer’s Guide

How pricing, safety, and the fine print actually work — so you book private with your eyes open, never overpay, and never get burned.

By Liam · charterwithliam.com

START HERE

Who this is for

You're thinking about flying private — maybe for the first time, maybe because the last time left a bad taste. You've seen the eye-watering quotes, the suspiciously cheap "deals," and the wall of jargon between you and a simple yes. This guide cuts through all of it.

It's for the traveler who wants the real story: what a charter actually costs and why, how to read a quote line by line, the safety questions that separate true operators from middlemen, and how empty legs let you fly for a fraction of retail. No upsell, no fluff — just what an honest broker would tell a friend.

Read it once and you'll negotiate like someone who's done this a hundred times.

THE LANDSCAPE

01 The three ways to fly private

Almost every private flight is bought one of three ways. They differ in commitment, cost structure, and who carries the risk. Match the model to how you actually travel — not to how often you imagine you will.

	On-demand charter	Jet card	Fractional
How it works	Book a single trip on whatever aircraft is available.	Prepay for a block of hours at a fixed hourly rate.	Buy a share of a specific aircraft; fly a set number of hours.
Upfront cost	None — pay per trip.	$100k–$500k deposit, typical.	$400k–$2M+ to buy in, plus monthly fees.
Best for	A few trips a year, flexible routes.	25–50+ hours a year, want price certainty.	200+ hours a year, want guaranteed availability.
Price per hour	Lowest sticker, varies by trip.	Fixed, with a premium baked in.	Highest all-in, but most predictable.
The catch	Price and aircraft change every time.	Premium for convenience; watch the fine print.	Large capital tied up; depreciation is yours.

> **The honest default:** if you fly fewer than ~25 hours a year, on-demand charter almost always wins. Cards and fractional sell convenience and certainty — you pay for both whether you use them or not.

THE ECONOMICS

02 What actually drives the price

A charter quote isn't pulled from the air. It's built from a handful of cost levers. Understand them and you can predict a fair number before anyone sends you one.

- **Aircraft category.** Turboprop → light → midsize → super-mid → heavy → ultra-long-range. Each step up roughly doubles the hourly burn.
- **Flight time, not distance.** You pay for hours in the air. Headwinds, routing, and fuel stops all add billable time.
- **Repositioning.** If the jet isn't based where you depart, you pay for it to fly to you — empty — and often to fly home.
- **Daily minimums.** Most operators bill a minimum of 1–2 hours per day, so a 30-minute hop still costs an hour-plus.
- **Crew & overnights.** Multi-day trips mean crew hotels, per diems, and duty-time limits that can force a second crew.
- **Peak days & short notice.** Holidays, big events, and sub-48-hour bookings command surcharges. Supply is finite.
- **Airport fees.** Landing, ramp, and de-icing fees vary wildly. Teterboro and Aspen are not Toledo.

✓ GREEN FLAG

You can lower the number

Flexible dates, a round trip that keeps the jet with you (avoiding two repositioning legs), and departing from a field where aircraft are already based all push the quote down. Ask for them.

THE PAPERWORK

03 How to read a quote

A clean quote tells you exactly what you're buying. A murky one hides the markup. Here's what each line means and where surprises like to hide.

- **Aircraft & tail number.** A real quote names the specific aircraft or at least the exact make/model — not just "midsize jet, or similar."
- **Occupied vs. total flight time.** Confirm whether repositioning legs are itemized or folded into one number.
- **Federal Excise Tax (FET).** 7.5% on domestic charter. If it's missing, ask — it's not optional, just sometimes hidden until invoicing.
- **Fuel surcharge.** Should be a line, not a moving target. Ask if it's capped.
- **Landing, handling & segment fees.** Small individually, meaningful together. They should be listed, not "TBD."
- **Catering & ground transport.** Often pass-through. Know what's included before you assume it is.
- **Cancellation terms.** The single most important paragraph. Read it before you read the price.

RED FLAG

"All-in" that isn't

If a broker quotes one flat number with no breakdown and waves off itemization, slow down. You can't verify what you can't see — and you can't negotiate it either.

NON-NEGOTIABLES

04 The safety questions that matter

Most people booking private have no idea whether they're talking to the operator who holds the certificate or a broker three steps removed. These questions cut straight to it.

- **"Who holds the operating certificate for this flight?"** You want the Part 135 operator's name — the entity legally responsible for the flight.
- **"Is this aircraft on that operator's certificate?"** Brokering a jet that isn't is a major red flag.
- **"What's your safety rating?"** ARGUS, Wyvern, or IS-BAO are the recognized third-party audits. Ask for the current tier.
- **"What are the pilots' hours and currency?"** Two qualified, type-current pilots — not one, not a contractor flying an unfamiliar type.
- **"Is there insurance, and what's the liability limit?"** You can ask to be named as an additional insured.

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A good operator answers instantly

Certificate holder, safety rating, insurance limits — a legitimate operator has these at their fingertips and shares them without friction. Hesitation or deflection is your answer.

THE DISCOUNT

05 How empty legs work

When a jet flies one way for a client, it often has to return — or reposition to its next trip — empty. The operator is paying for that flight regardless, so any revenue beats none. That's why empty legs sell for up to 75% off retail.

- **The trade-off is flexibility.** Empty legs run on the jet's schedule, not yours. The closer you can flex on date, time, and exact airport, the more deals open up.
- **They're perishable.** A leg exists only until the aircraft moves. Many surface 24–72 hours out and vanish fast.
- **They can change or cancel.** If the original paying trip moves, the empty leg moves with it. Have a backup plan for anything truly time-critical.
- **Routes matter.** Busy corridors — LA–Vegas, South Florida–Northeast, NY–Florida — generate the most empty legs.

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How to actually catch them

Tell a broker your home airports and the routes you fly, then let them filter the firehose for you. Matched alerts beat refreshing a public empty-leg page every morning — the good ones are gone before they're ever posted.

BEFORE YOU WIRE A DEPOSIT

06 The pre-booking checklist

One page to run through before money changes hands. If you can’t tick all ten, you have a question to ask — not a deposit to send.

- ☐ Confirmed the Part 135 operator who holds the certificate for the flight.
- ☐ Verified the aircraft is on that operator’s certificate.
- ☐ Asked for the safety rating (ARGUS / Wyvern / IS-BAO).
- ☐ Got an itemized quote — flight time, FET, fuel, fees all listed.
- ☐ Confirmed whether repositioning legs are included in the price.
- ☐ Read the cancellation and change terms in full.
- ☐ Checked what’s included: catering, ground transport, Wi-Fi, de-icing.
- ☐ Confirmed pilot count, type-currency, and insurance limits.
- ☐ Asked about flexible dates or a round trip to lower the cost.
- ☐ Have the operator’s direct contact for the day of travel.

YOUR MOVE

Have a trip in mind?

Send your route and dates and I’ll find the right flight at the right price — and flag the empty legs that match before they disappear.

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